The Grave That Was Double-Guarded Against the Undead

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In 2022, **archaeologists** unearthed an unsettling grave in Pie?, in north-central Poland. The young woman buried there, whom researchers call Zosia, was 17 to 19 years old when she died. A sickle blade was hooked over her throat, and a triangular padlock hung on the big toe of her left foot.

"The placement of the sickle and the padlock suggests that the purpose of these practices was to protect the living from Zosia after her death," says Dariusz Poli?ski, an archaeologist at Nicolaus Copernicus University in Toru?, Poland, who led the **excavation**. That included, "without a doubt, preventing her from rising from the grave." The team's findings appeared in the October issue of Journal of Archaeological Science: Reports. Sickles and padlocks have each been found in other European tombs to shield the living from the dead, but Zosia's grave is the first known to use both.

Clues suggest the precautions happened in two stages. The way her leg bones lay hints the padlock was latched on her toe when she was first buried, as if someone suspected she might try to rise right away. Mixed-up soil and the odd angle of her left arm suggest someone later dug the tomb up to place the sickle over her throat. Greenish stains on her skull could have come from a copper object placed in her mouth or nose, possibly another protective measure: in Polish **folklore**, copper was thought to ward off vampiric demons called **strzygi**. In this historical context, a "vampire" simply meant a harmful undead being, not the garlic-and-capes monster of today.

Chemical clues paint a picture of Zosia's life. Types of strontium and oxygen atoms in her teeth suggest she grew up near Pie?, while her DNA hints her mother's family might have come from **Scandinavia**. Remnants of a silk cap on her head contained threads of pure silver and gold, suggesting she was a wealthy woman of high social status. That is unusual: people given strange burials were often outsiders or had hard lives, but Zosia seems to have been a local noblewoman. There are no obvious marks of injury or illness on her skeleton, and researchers say they are still examining her DNA for insights into how she died.

Word Treasure

archaeologists -- Scientists who dig up and study things left behind by people in the past.

excavation -- The careful digging of a site to uncover objects or remains buried underground.

folklore -- Traditional stories and beliefs passed down by ordinary people in a community.

strzygi -- Harmful undead demons in Polish folklore that people believed copper could ward off.

Scandinavia -- The northern European region that includes countries such as Norway, Sweden, and Denmark.

Background you need

Archaeologists study the past by digging up graves, tools, and other remains and reading the clues they leave behind.

In some old European communities, people feared that certain dead people might rise and harm the living.

To prevent this, they sometimes buried the dead with special objects meant to hold the body down or block it from rising.

Clues in bones, teeth, and buried objects can also tell researchers where a person grew up and what kind of life they may have lived.

Break it down

LEAD: In 2022, archaeologists unearthed an unsettling grave in Pie?, in north-central Poland, holding a young woman researchers call Zosia.

KEY EVENT: Zosia, aged 17 to 19 at death, was buried with a sickle blade hooked over her throat and a triangular padlock on the big toe of her left foot.

+- WHO: Dariusz Poli?ski, the archaeologist who led the excavation, says the placement suggests the practices were meant to protect the living and prevent her from rising.

+- WHY IT IS FIRST: Sickles and padlocks have each been found in other European tombs, but this is the first known grave to use both.

EVIDENCE OF TWO STAGES: Leg bones hint the padlock was latched at the first burial, while mixed-up soil and her left arm's odd angle suggest the tomb was later dug up to place the sickle.

FOLKLORE CLUE: Greenish stains could come from a copper object in her mouth or nose, and Polish folklore held that copper warded off vampiric demons called strzygi.

LIFE CLUES: Teeth suggest she grew up near Pie?, DNA hints her mother's family might have come from Scandinavia, and a silk cap with silver and gold threads suggests a wealthy local noblewoman.

OPEN QUESTION: There are no obvious marks of injury or illness, and researchers are still examining her DNA for insights into how she died.

Why it matters

The grave shows how fear and folklore shaped the way past communities treated the dead, and how careful study of bones and buried objects can recover the life story of someone history would otherwise forget.

Test what you remember

1. Where and when was Zosia's grave unearthed?

- (A) In southern Poland, in the October issue
- (B) In Toru? in October
- (C) In Pie?, in north-central Poland, in 2022
- (D) In Scandinavia in 2022

2. How old was Zosia when she died?

- (A) Her age is unknown
- (B) About 10 years old
- (C) 17 to 19 years old
- (D) Over 30 years old

3. What two objects were found with Zosia?

- (A) A garlic wreath and a wooden stake
- (B) A silk cap and a padlock on her hand
- (C) A sickle blade over her throat and a triangular padlock on the big toe of her left foot
- (D) A copper coin and a silver necklace

4. What makes Zosia's grave the first known of its kind?

- (A) It is the first known grave to use both a sickle and a padlock
- (B) It is the first grave found in Poland
- (C) It is the first grave with a silk cap
- (D) It is the first grave dug up by archaeologists

5. What do clues suggest about the order of the precautions?

- (A) The sickle came first and the padlock was added years later
- (B) The padlock was latched at the first burial and the sickle was added later after the tomb was dug up again
- (C) Neither was placed by people at all
- (D) Both were placed at the same moment by the same person

6. Why is Zosia's high status unusual, according to the body?

- (A) Because people given strange burials were often outsiders or had hard lives, while she seems to have been a local noblewoman
- (B) Because her DNA came from Scandinavia
- (C) Because noblewomen were never buried with silk
- (D) Because she had no marks of injury

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: C 4: A 5: B 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Excavation leader Dariusz Poli?ski: The placement of the sickle and padlock suggests the practices were meant to protect the living from Zosia after her death, including, without a doubt, preventing her from rising from the grave.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):